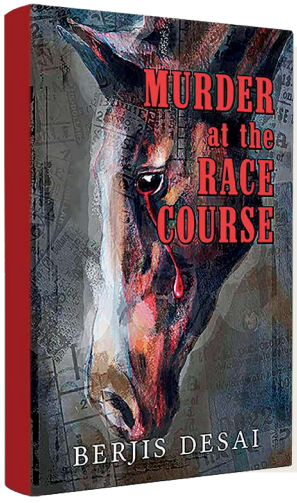
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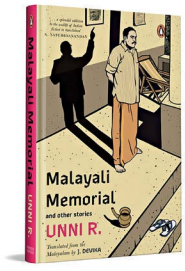
of 2024 present a cabinet of curiosities



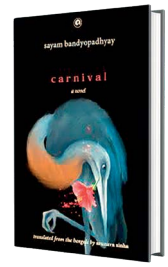
MURDER AT THE RACE COURSE
By Berjis Desai
SHREE BOOK CENTRE
₹399; 238 pages

It's probably a little unusual to define a murder mystery as 'epic'. Certainly not when the crime takes place within the closed circle of the famed Mahalakshmi Race Course of Mumbai. Yet, the moment Berjis Desai gets a leg up on his horse and the first shot is fired, you're up there in a whirlwind of blood and lust. A lawyer, a brilliant writer with a penchant for exposing the eccentricities of his Parsi proletariat, Desai is also an owner and breeder of thoroughbreds. His characters come out from separate stalls. Their bloodline is rich with intrigue, not just the odd maharaja, or the lusciously endowed women, but also grifters from the Partition era. Like a besotted lover, Desai both exposes and celebrates the world of racehorses and their minders.

MALAYALI MEMORIAL AND OTHER STORIES
By Unni R.
(Translated from the Malayalam by J. Devika)
PENGUIN/VINTAGE
₹599; 232 pages



There is both sunshine and sudden squalls of pelting rain in the short story selection that reveals Unni R.'s oeuvre in all its unsettling trajectory. The mundane and the miraculous are given equal billing. While sex and the intimate descriptions of bodily functions are a part of the Malayali writer's repertoire, Unni specialises in detonating brisk and epigrammatic endings. It's to the credit of the translator, J. Devika, that she's able to convey the same shock effects with a minimum of means, and in a language that has its own laconic rhythms of dealing with effluvia of the physical kind.



CARNIVAL: A NOVEL
By Sayam Bandyopadhyay
(Translated from the Bengali by Arunava Sinha)
ALEPH
₹499; 168 pages

This is an extraordinary piece of work that tosses you up and down on myriad fragments of history like a carousel ride gone rogue. Sayan Bandyopadhyay has wound his clock so that it reverts to the year 1857. The protagonist Rajaram's dilemma is that he is trapped between his inner world and tormenting visions that appear to him at night. He finds relief in the word 'Carnival'. It is a key that unlocks a well-known character from the Western pantheon—Mephisto—who comes with his own followers. Will Rajaram make the leap? Exquisitely translated by Arunava Sinha.

IN ANTICIPATION

GIANTS
By Huthuka Sumi
(Forthcoming from HarperCollins)

Huthuka Sumi is a first-time author-photographer from the Sumi tribe of Nagaland. In *Giants*, Kato, a young, mute boy, listens to the stories and legends about the Naga world that his mother tells him, when he hears a knock on the door. There are many changes happening outside, including the Second World War raging on the threshold, at Kohima. Kato finds a giant outside, looking for a storyteller. It sounds irresistible.

